

INDUSTRY GUIDE · No. 01 · BAKERY

BAKERY?

Sourdough starters, 4 a.m. shifts and the craft behind the UK's favourite loaves.

A working introduction to the people, businesses and routes that keep Britain in bread, pastries and cake. Written for anyone — 16 to 30 — leaving school, switching careers or just curious about the trade.

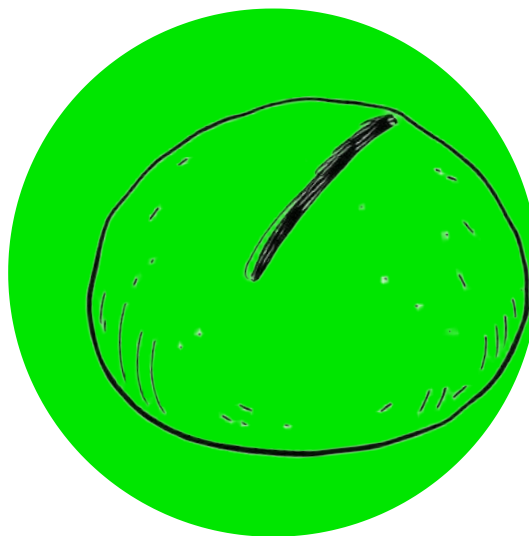


12 EMPLOYERS

20+ ROLES

4 ROUTES IN

£14K-£55K+



FROMHOWDOYOU.DO.GROUP

~ rise ~ prove bake.

how do you
bake bread?

CONTENTS

Inside this booklet.

Eight short chapters. Real numbers, real companies, real entry points — pulled from our live Bakery hub at howdoyoudo.group. Read it cover to cover, or jump straight to the bit you need.

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rise.

CHAPTER ONE

The shape of UK bakery.

UK bakery runs from neighbourhood artisan shops to industrial plant bakeries pushing millions of loaves a day into the supermarkets. Three tiers, very different careers.

£5bn+ANNUAL UK RETAIL VALUE
OF BREAD & BAKERY**11m**LOAVES & BREAD-
EQUIVALENTS SOLD EACH
DAY**3.**DISTINCT TIERS — PLANT,
IN-STORE, CRAFT**~80%**SHARE OF UK BREAD
BAKED BY PLANT
BAKERIES**Plant bakeries.**

Large-scale, highly automated 24/7 operations supplying the major supermarkets. Engineers, line operators, quality technicians and despatch teams work alongside bakers; automation handles mixing, dividing, proving, baking, cooling, slicing and packing. The trade-off is scale — one site can bake for an entire region.

In-store bakeries.

Inside the supermarkets — Tesco, Sainsbury's, Morrisons, Asda. Often a hybrid of par-baked product and on-site finishing. A fast, accessible route into the trade with structured shifts and clear progression into store and area management.

Craft & artisan.

Independent shops, micro-bakeries and bakery-cafés. Sourdough teams shape the night before; pastry sections run a parallel shift, laminating croissant dough across multiple days. Smaller margins, longer hours — but a direct, visible craft and a real route to running your own.

Why it matters.

Few industries let a 16-year-old apprentice and a 40-year-old head baker stand at the same bench and learn from each other. Bakery is one of them. It rewards reliability, hands-on craft and a head for numbers — and the route to self-employment is genuinely walkable.

Figures are indicative, drawn from UK trade body and market research reporting.

CHAPTER TWO

A working morning.

A bakery runs on unusual hours. In a craft shop, production typically starts between 2 a.m. and 5 a.m. so bread is on the shelf when the doors open. Here's what an average shift actually looks like.

06:30 – first deliveries leave the door

- | | |
|-------|--|
| 03:00 | Head baker arrives. Ovens fired up. Pre-mixed doughs come out of overnight retardation. |
| 04:30 | Shaping and scoring. First bakes in the oven. Pastry chef begins laminated viennoiserie. |
| 06:30 | First deliveries leave for wholesale customers — cafés, restaurants, hotels. |
| 08:00 | Shopfront opens. Front-of-house take over service. Bakers prep tomorrow's doughs. |
| 14:00 | Wash-down, stock check, ordering. Head baker hands over to the overnight team. |

What it takes.

Reliability. A bakery runs on fixed bake-off times — colleagues, drivers and customers all depend on you turning up.

Attention to detail. Small changes in weights, hydration or temperature produce very different loaves. Consistency is a professional skill.

Stamina. Lifting, shaping and standing for long shifts is part of the job at every level.

And what helps.

Numeracy. Bakers' percentages, scaling recipes, costing and yield calculations are daily work.

Care for people. Whether you're serving customers or leading a production team, people skills determine how far you progress.

Curiosity. The best bakers we've met all keep a starter at home. None of them stopped learning.

CHAPTER THREE

What's shaping the next decade.

Three forces are reshaping bakery right now: how we eat, what it costs, and what machines can do. Here's the honest version — opportunities and pressure points side by side.

Trends

Premium & craft growth.

Sourdough, heritage grains, high-hydration breads — skilled craft bakers in demand.

Health-driven

reformulation. Lower-salt, higher-fibre, fortified products are now strategic priorities.

Plant-based & free-from.

Gluten-free, vegan and allergen-friendly lines are mainstream — opening NPD routes.

Hybrid bakery-café.

Independents combining retail, wholesale and eat-in create cross-skill roles.

Direct-to-consumer.

Subscriptions, online classes and shipped loaves give small producers national reach.

Challenges

Input costs. Flour, butter, cocoa and energy have been volatile — independents feel it first.

Skills shortages. Fewer young bakers entering craft. Experienced night bakers in high demand.

Unsocial hours. Early starts, nights and weekends are real — particularly in craft and plant.

Compliance load. Allergen labelling, HACCP, hygiene ratings, post-Brexit import paperwork.

Physical demands. Heat, lifting, long periods on your feet. It suits people who like active work.

What's next

Affordable automation.

Smaller mixers, dividers and deck ovens letting indies scale without losing quality.

Sustainability. Surplus-bread reuse, regenerative wheat, energy-efficient ovens — moving from edge to expectation.

Ingredient innovation. UK heritage wheats, rye, spelt, einkorn, novel proteins — expanding what 'bread' means.

Data & supply chain. Plant bakeries investing in predictive ordering — opening technical roles.

EV last-mile. Cargo-bike and electric-van models reshaping the urban wholesale round.

CHAPTER FOUR

Four ways to start.

There is no single path into bakery. Many successful bakers started with no formal training and learned on the job. The four most common routes are below — pick the one that fits your life.

Route	Age	What it actually looks like	Best suited to
Apprenticeship	16–24	Paid role in a craft or plant bakery + off-the-job study. Level 2 (Baker) and Level 3 (Senior Production Chef).	<i>School-leavers and switchers who learn by doing.</i>
College course	16–30	FE patisserie, bakery or professional cookery — or specialist bread school short courses.	<i>Those who want a structured grounding first.</i>
Counter to bench	16–30	Start in a bakery-café in retail or KP and move into production once you've proved yourself.	<i>People unsure if the hours will suit them.</i>
Career switcher	22–30+	Move from hospitality, food retail or unrelated work, backed by weekend courses and home practice.	<i>Self-starters treating bakery as their own apprenticeship.</i>

Apprenticeship pay.

Bakery apprentices in the UK typically earn **£14k–£20k** while training, qualifying within 12–24 months. Level 2 (Baker) and Level 3 (Senior Production Chef) are the standards. Live vacancies are listed on the Government's **Find an Apprenticeship** portal.

Worth knowing.

Most independents will allow a trial shift or day visit. **Do one before you commit** — an early start is the best test of whether the lifestyle suits you. Then talk to two bakers at different tiers; a craft baker and a plant production team leader will describe very different jobs. Both are valid.

CHAPTER FIVE

From flour to franchise.

Every role in the bakery value chain — pulled live from our Bakery career map. Pay ranges are indicative UK figures for full-time roles; London, premium-brand and independent roles often sit at the top end.

01 Ingredients & Sourcing		
Flour Miller	Sources and mills grain into specialist flours for bakeries.	£22k-£30k
Ingredient Buyer	Negotiates supply contracts for butter, sugar, yeast and specialty ingredients.	£28k-£40k
Quality Assurance Manager	Tests raw materials and ensures compliance with food safety standards.	£30k-£45k

02 Production & Baking		
Artisan Baker	Hand-crafts sourdough, pastries and speciality breads.	£22k-£32k
Head Baker	Leads production schedules, recipe development and kitchen teams.	£30k-£42k
Pastry Chef	Creates cakes, viennoiserie and decorated celebration pieces.	£24k-£36k
NPD Chef	Develops new products, testing flavours and formats for market.	£28k-£42k
Food Technologist	Applies food science to improve shelf life, texture and process.	£26k-£40k
Production Operative	Operates mixing, baking and packaging machinery.	£20k-£26k

CHAPTER FIVE / CONTINUED

...and out into the business.

The roles that turn a bakery into a brand — shopfront, marketing, growth and ownership.

03 Distribution & Wholesale

Wholesale Account Manager	Manages relationships with cafés, restaurants and retailers.	£28k-£40k
Delivery Driver	Runs early-morning routes getting fresh products to customers.	£22k-£28k
Logistics Coordinator	Plans delivery routes, manages cold-chain and dispatch.	£24k-£35k

04 Retail & Shopfront

Bakery Manager	Runs day-to-day operations, staffing, stock and customer experience.	£26k-£35k
Counter Staff	Serves customers, handles till and maintains displays.	£20k-£24k
Café Manager	Manages the eat-in side of bakery-café operations.	£24k-£32k

05 Brand & Marketing

Brand Manager	Develops the bakery's identity, packaging and social presence.	£30k-£45k
Food Photographer	Shoots product imagery for menus, social and press.	£25k-£40k

06 Business & Growth

Franchise Manager	Oversees expansion, new site launches and franchisee relations.	£35k-£55k
Bakery Owner	Runs the entire business — from recipes to rent.	Varies widely

CHAPTER SIX

Companies to know.

A starter list of UK bakery employers worth knowing — pulled from our live company directory. From plant production at Warburtons to Borough Market sourdough at Bread Ahead.

Warburtons**Production**

FOUNDED 1876 · HQ BOLTON

UK's largest family-owned bakery — 2 million loaves daily.

Allied Bakeries**Production**

FOUNDED 1935 · HQ MAIDENHEAD

Kingsmill and Allinson's, baked at industrial scale.

Hovis**Production**

FOUNDED 1886 · HQ HIGH WYCOMBE

Iconic British bread brand with 130+ years of heritage.

Greggs**Retail**

FOUNDED 1939 · HQ NEWCASTLE

The UK's largest bakery chain — 2,000+ shops.

Gail's Bakery**Retail**

FOUNDED 2005 · HQ LONDON

Neighbourhood bakeries known for sourdough and pastries.

Ole & Steen**Retail**

FOUNDED 2018 · HQ LONDON

Danish bakery bringing Scandi traditions to the UK high street.

Paul UK**Retail**

FOUNDED 1889 · HQ LONDON

French-inspired artisan bakery and café chain.

Bread Ahead**Retail**

FOUNDED 2013 · HQ LONDON

Borough Market sourdough, doughnuts and a baking school.

Hobbs House**Retail**

FOUNDED 1920 · HQ GLOUCESTERSHIRE

Family-run, slow-fermented bread baked since 1920.

Shipton Mill**Sourcing**

FOUNDED 1981 · HQ GLOUCESTERSHIRE

Organic stoneground flour for top UK bakeries.

Marriage's Flour**Sourcing**

FOUNDED 1824 · HQ CHELMSFORD

One of the UK's oldest independent flour millers.

Carr's Flour**Sourcing**

FOUNDED 1831 · HQ CUMBRIA

Major flour miller — artisan and industrial supply.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Where to look next.

The shortlist we'd actually use. Three podcasts, three trade reads, four schools — every one verified on the live Bakery hub.

Listen.

**My Baking Journey**

OLBAA's stories of UK bakers and their routes in.

olbaa.uk/my-baking-journey-podcast

**The Business of Cake Making**

UK podcast on running a baking business — pricing, marketing, growth.

thebusinessofcakemaking.podbean.com

**The Food Programme**

BBC Radio 4's long-running take on food, farming and baking culture.

bbc.co.uk/programmes/b006qnx3

Read.

**British Baker**

The trade title of record for UK bakery.

bakeryinfo.co.uk

**Craft Bakers Association**

Trade body for independent bakers — training, events, resources.

craftbakersassociation.co.uk

**Federation of Bakers**

Plant and territorial bakers — production, NPD, technical careers.

fob.uk.com

Learn.

School of Artisan Food WELBECK

Diplomas, short courses and the gold-standard route into craft.

Bread Ahead Bakery School LONDON

Borough Market courses from sourdough to viennoiserie.

E5 Bakehouse LONDON

Hackney's sourdough school inside a working bakery.

National Bakery School LONDON

Part of LSBU — the UK's oldest bakery school (est. 1894).

CHAPTER EIGHT

A starter checklist.

Eight things to do this month. None of them cost much. All of them give you something real to put on a CV — or to know whether bakery is, actually, for you.

☐**Spend a day in a working bakery.**

Most independents will let you trial. The 4 a.m. start is the best test you can take.

☐**Talk to two bakers at different tiers.**

A craft baker and a plant team leader. Two genuinely different jobs.

☐**Start a sourdough starter at home.**

Keep it for a month. One consistent loaf is a credible signal to any employer.

☐**Browse live UK bakery jobs.**

Filter the marketplace at howdoyoudo.group/marketplace?industry=Bakery.

☐**Subscribe to British Baker.**

Free industry email — the fastest way to learn the trade's vocabulary.

☐**Book a weekend short course.**

Bread Ahead, E5 or School of Artisan Food. A taster before you commit.

☐**Search 'Find an Apprenticeship'.**

Filter by 'baker' on gov.uk/apply-apprenticeship — live vacancies, paid.

☐**Build your CV in the Howdy CV builder.**

Free, AI-tailored to bakery roles at every stage of the value chain.

Keep going

The full Bakery hub — live jobs, daily news, podcasts, day-in-the-life profiles, a CV builder and our 'Howdy' AI assistant — is waiting at:

howdoyoudo.group/bakery